Designed Productive Struggle

A practical guide for leaders and facilitators

How to tell the difference between work that moves the needle and work that is merely hard

Most organizations fill time with work that is either easy and unimportant or hard and unimportant. Designed Productive Struggle is the deliberate design of work that sits in the upper-right of the Work Quadrant: important enough to matter and difficult enough to require real capability. Its purpose is not to make people struggle. Its purpose is to ensure that the capacity of the organization is spent on problems whose solution changes an outcome the market, the customer, or the business actually cares about. When that standard is met, difficulty becomes productive. When it is not, difficulty becomes waste.

What it is

Designed Productive Struggle is not difficulty for its own sake. It is the intentional design of work that is hard because it matters. If the goal is to move the needle in the market—whether that means winning a customer, changing a process that has real cost, or solving a problem competitors have not solved—the work will be definitionally difficult. The question is not whether the work is hard. The question is whether the hardness is productive.

Three tests for important work

1. Does it move a real outcome?

The work connects to something a customer, market, or business cares about. Completing it changes a result that can be observed—revenue, cost, speed, quality, risk, or competitive position. If the only person who notices the outcome is the team that produced it, the work is probably not important enough.

2. Is the difficulty inherent, not added?

The hardness comes from the nature of the problem itself (ambiguity, trade-offs, resistance, incomplete information, coordination across boundaries). It is not created by unclear goals, poor process, missing information that could have been provided, or unnecessary layers of review. Designed Productive Struggle removes friction that does not serve the outcome and leaves the friction that does.

3. Can people see the connection between effort and result?

Those doing the work understand why this particular difficulty is worth enduring. They can explain, in plain language, what will be different if they succeed and what will not change if they do not. When that connection is missing, effort turns into cynicism or theater.

Common substitutes for Designed Productive Struggle

Busywork that feels serious	Reports, meetings, or analyses that consume capacity but do not change a decision or outcome.
Difficulty from poor design	Unclear ownership, missing data, conflicting priorities, or rework caused by the system rather than the problem.
Heroics as a substitute for design	Relying on exceptional individual effort to compensate for work that has not been structured to succeed.
Activity that protects the status quo	Work that is hard but primarily maintains existing processes, relationships, or narratives rather than testing or advancing them.

A short facilitation sequence (45–60 minutes)

1. **Name the work.** Write a single sentence describing the work under consideration. Avoid solution language. Focus on the outcome the work is intended to produce.
2. **Apply the three tests.** Ask the group to answer each of the three tests above. Capture where the answers are clear and where they diverge.
3. **Identify the real source of difficulty.** Separate difficulty that comes from the problem itself from difficulty that comes from how the work is currently designed. List both.
4. **Decide.** Either redesign the work so the remaining difficulty is productive, or stop or deprioritize the work because the connection to a real outcome is too weak.

Designed Productive Struggle is not a motivational concept. It is a design standard. Work that moves the needle will be hard. The job of leaders is to make sure the hardness is the right hardness.